



STANKY

BOB INGRAM

The strange Stanky case; more firings?

EDDIE STANKY'S sudden turnaround was a Diablo dugout conversation piece before last night's game with Midland.

Bob Rodgers, the Diablo manager, Al Kubi, chief of the California Angels west coast scouts, and George Noga, an instructor for the Angels, thought it was a strange thing indeed for a major league manager to quit after being on the job only one day.

Stanky piloted the Rangers to a 10-8 triumph over Minnesota Thursday night and then departed for his home in Alabama yesterday morning, explaining that he had a swift case of homesickness.

"He must be the only manager in the big leagues to end up with a 1,000 per cent," one of the Angel men said.

He was reminded that Andy Cohen had such a perfect record when he managed the Philadelphia Phils one night.

But Andy didn't walk away from that job voluntarily. He was merely pinch-hitting for Gene Mauch.

Stanky's decision to quit after one night with the Rangers is not any more strange than college football or basketball coaches taking jobs and then changing their minds. There have been a number of them.

Some people might wonder if the Rangers are so bad that they would turn off a manager in one night. Probably not, but in these times when there are so many rebellious players in the big leagues, the job of running a team may not be as enchanting as it used to be.

THE EL PASO dugout talk got around to the subject of managers who didn't depart on their own accord this season but have been forced out.

There have been five managerial firings in the majors so far this season. They are: Joe Frazier of the New York Mets, Frank Robinson of the Cleveland Indians, Frank Lucchesi of the Texas Rangers, John McNamara of the San Diego Padres and Jack McKeon of the Oakland A's. And there was the close scrape Billy Martin of the Yankees had with the executioner.

There likely will be some more firings this year. Guessing where the ax will fall is a favorite pastime now. The owners of the big league clubs are playing Russian roulette with their managers. It could be like living in Boston during the days of the Boston Strangler. Nobody knew who would be

his next victim.

These managers seem assured of finishing the season: American—Earl Weaver, Baltimore; Don Zimmer, Boston; Bob Lemon, Chicago; Jeff Torborg, Cleveland; Whitey Herzog, Kansas City; Alex Grammas, Milwaukee; Gene Mauch, Minnesota; Darrell Johnson, Seattle, and Roy Hartsfield, Toronto.

National—Herman Franks, Chicago; Sparky Anderson, Cincinnati; Tom Lasorda, Los Angeles; Joe Torre, New York; Danny Ozark, Philadelphia; Chuck Tanner, Pittsburgh; Vern Rapp, St. Louis, and Alvin Dark, San Diego.

Unlike death and taxes, there's nothing sure about them but they appear to have the best chance of 1977 survival.

THE MANAGERS who may be high on the endangered list are: National—Dave Bristol, Atlanta; Bill Virdon, Houston; Dick Williams, Montreal; Joe Altobelli, San Francisco; American—Norm Sherry, California; Ralph Houk, Detroit; Billy Martin, New York; Bobby Winkles, Oakland, and Connie Ryan, Texas.

Some of them may have as much security as the Chase Manhattan National Bank. But to me they seem to be the most suspect.

Billy Martin got a reprieve this week. He's still not out of the woods. No telling when and if Charley Finley will ax Winkles. Ryan, of course, is working on an interim basis.

Sherry, I regret to say, is on the list of expendables. The former El Paso manager probably knows that time may be running out.

The Angels, with all that high priced talent, have not been able to put it altogether and win with any consistency. They need to go on a tear and win 10 in a row and 14 out of 15 to make Sherry's job easier.

After the Angels' 6-2 loss to Chicago Thursday night, Sherry said: "I'm disappointed. The talent is out there, but we haven't been able to get going. We need runs in a streak. But we can't wait forever and get too far behind."

Bobby Grich's backbone, Don Baylor's low batting average, Nolan Ryan's wildness — they haven't helped Sherry. There may be a few more holes too on the California team than observers thought there were. Anyway, the Angels' failure to play up to their potential could cost Sherry his job, even though it might not be his fault.

Stanky spurns \$300,000 pay

MOBILE, Ala. (UPI) — "I guess I'm a prime example that money doesn't buy happiness," said Eddie Stanky.

Stanky returned to Mobile and the University of South Alabama Thursday after a one-day stint as manager of the Texas Rangers. He had agreed Wednesday to a three-year contract that called for a quarter-million dollars.

In addition, Stanky said, "I would have gotten \$50,000 bonus for winning the division."

STANKY JOINED the Rangers in Minneapolis but Wednesday night "after the excitement calmed down I started getting lonesome and homesick."

After the game with the Twins, he said, "I got to the room and couldn't sleep. I called my wife around five after six (Thursday morning) and I told her I was coming home."

